Graphic Design

Power Tools In Photoshop

Summary Notes

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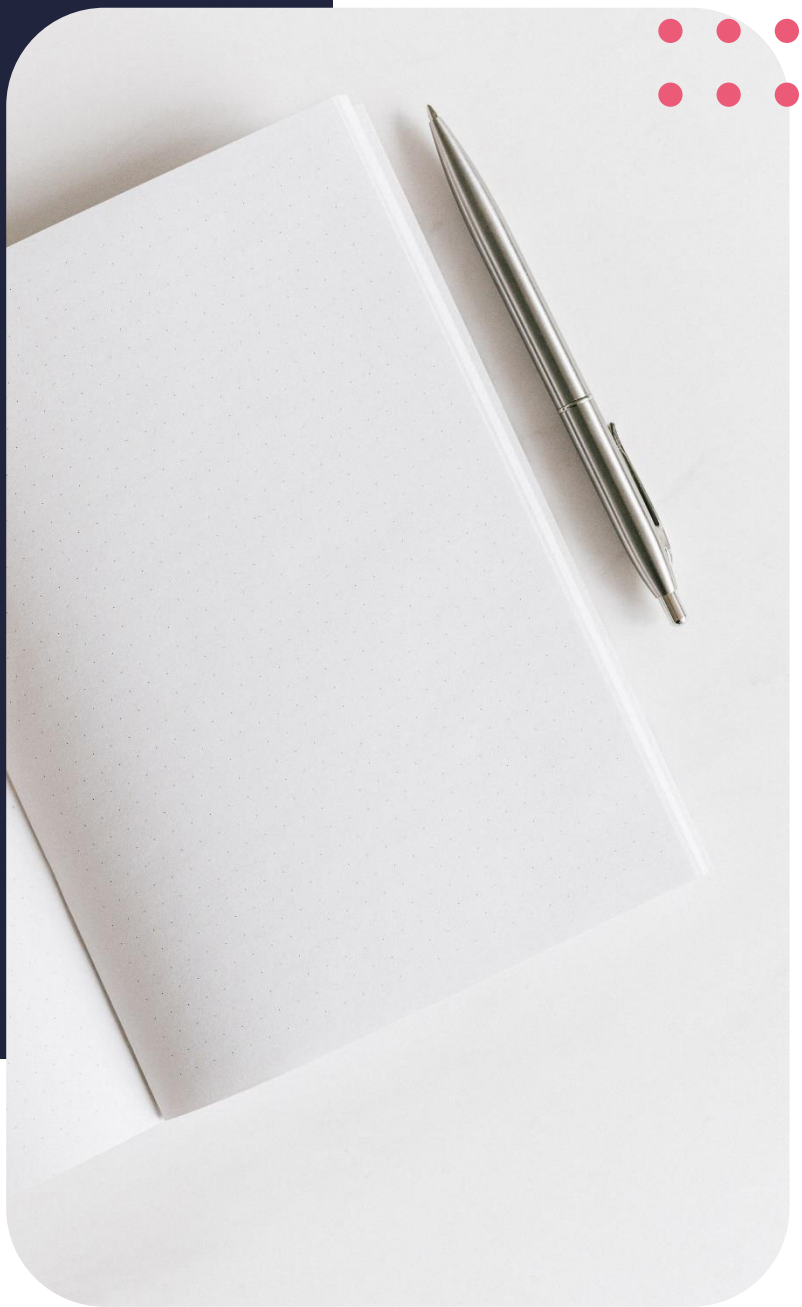

Introduction

Our focus for today's lesson will be to learn some amazing tools in Photoshop that you might not have even hear of or realised you can do.

We will start off by creating actions in Photoshop. Actions are useful for not only speeding up your workflow but also useful for bulk editing

You will learn how to create your very own Photoshop brushes and also where to access brushes if you would rather want to download these

The automate function in Photoshop allows you to create HDR images as well as stitching images together to form a panorama.

Ending off, you will be introduced to the timeline panel that allows you to create motion in Photoshop. We will use this function to create an animated GIF.

Photoshop actions

Why use Photoshop actions?

So, what can you use Photoshop Actions for? It can be used for all sorts of editing including bulk resizing of images, colour correcting and other enhancements.

Here is an example let's say you have a batch of photographs that you want to resize and sharpen. Instead of opening each image and applying these effects individually, you can create a simple Photoshop action to process each of your images automatically.

Create actions in Photoshop

Photoshop actions allow the designer to set up processes that can be reused for the editing of an image in a particular way. This is a manual process of creating the action but once it is created, you can simply reuse it whenever you feel.

In other words, Photoshop actions enable you to record a repetitive process and save that information as an action which you can then use for other tasks down the road.

How to create an action

Open the actions panel

Record your action

Play your action

Manage and edit your action

Don't let repetitive tasks drain your creativity. We explain how to automate them by creating your own Photoshop actions. As a Photoshop user, you've probably run into a situation where you have had to do repetitive tasks, such as resizing images, creating vignettes or something else. Having to do all of this manually can be very time-consuming. Fortunately, there is an easier way, whether you're using an older CS Photoshop, the very latest Creative Cloud version, or even some newer versions of Photoshop Elements.

We will do a quick demo on creating your own action but I would like to explain the process to you first.

First, open the Actions panel from your top Menu.

Create a new action set and name accordingly.

Then, record your action. Recording an action is easy. Simply click on the icon at the top right of the Actions panel and in the popup, menu click on New Action.

To end the recording, simply press the stop button.

Your action is now created and you will apply it to any other images. Simply open your chosen images in Photoshop and play the action.

You will even be able to manage and edit your actions if and when needed.

For best results take some time to plan the steps of the actions before recording them and if necessary, write down all the steps on a piece of paper before you begin.

Actions Demo

Turning on Photoshop Actions

Be sure your action palette is visible. If it's not, go to Menu; Window; Actions (ALT or Option + F9)

Explore the Photoshop Actions panel: In the action panel you can create, play, stop, save, load, delete and

organize your actions.

Here's how:

1. Stop: Stop recording or playback

2. Record: Start recording a new action or adding new commands to any existing action

3. Play: Play a selected action back

4. New set: Create a new action set

5. New action: Adds a new action to a set

6. Delete: As you might expect, this button deletes a selected set, action or command

7. Action set: A folder which contains and organizes your actions, for example in different groups (Ex: color corrections, mockups, templates, etc.)

8. Action: The action itself. Imagine an action as a collection of many commands

(Ex: open image, resize image, transform image, etc.)

9. Steps/Command: A single Photoshop command. One or more commands together build an action.

10. Checkbox: Commands which are checked will be executed, while unchecked commands will not.

11. Menu dialog: With this icon you can control user input into an action. For example, say you record an action to apply a Gaussian Blur filter and by default, you set a radius of 2px.

12. Action panel menu

Make your own Photoshop brushes

At its most basic, the Photoshop brush tool is used for drawing lines and shapes in any colour on a layer in your document using strokes. After selecting a brush, you can draw simply by clicking the left mouse button a single time, or by holding it down and dragging your cursor around the page to create multiple marks with a single stroke.

Install a Photoshop brush

The types Throughout this lesson we will look at references of one-page resumes. Studying their layout, margins and structure to formulate our own resume. To design a one-page creative resume layout is based on a simple grid structure with two columns, and plenty of white space. The different sections are clearly marked out and divided from each other with subheadings and lines.

Brushes demo

Step 1: Create a new Photoshop document

Step 2: Select the brush tool

Step 3: Select a small round brush

Step 4: Make Sure the foreground colour is set to black

Step 5: Paint a series of horizontal brush strokes inside the document window

Step 6: Create A new brush from the document

Step 7: Open the brushes panel

Step 8: Adjust the brush tip spacing

Step 9: Select the shape dynamics option

Step 10: Set the angle control To direction

Step 11: Set the Size control Pen Pressure (Requires Pen Tablet)

Work with Photoshop's automate

One of my favourite styles of image is a panoramic photo. Creating this type of image in Adobe Photoshop is super easy thanks to the Photo merge command. You can take several images and combine them into a seamless panoramic image. You are also able to create and HDR, or high-dynamic range photograph. An HDR photograph has become very trendy—especially among photographers who enjoy creating surreal effects in their images. However, this technique can be used for photo-realism to combine multiple exposures into the ideal image as well.

Panoramic photograph

A panorama or panoramic photograph is an image consisting of a wide angle view capturing a complete subject. A panorama can be captured by stitching or combining a multitude of adjacent photographs and combining them to form a long landscape – almost like a puzzle consisting of only horizontal pieces. Sometimes, your camera just can't capture the full landscape or object, so instead of trying to capture everything in one photograph, you take a couple of photographs, making sure that each side overlaps with the adjacent photograph.

HDR photograph

High dynamic range

Improves the range of colours and contrast

Combines multiple images with different exposures

Have you ever taken a picture of a beautiful sunset only to have it not look like it does in real life? Either the foreground is too dark and you don't see any detail, or the background or sunset is too bright and you don't get to justify the range of colours in the sky? Well, there is a way to fix this by means of HDR. HDR is the abbreviation for high dynamic range. It is a technique where you improve the range of colours as well as contrast on a digital image. To do this, you need to capture multiple images of the same object at the same angle but at different exposures. First, you will capture an image that is

under exposed, this means that your image will be very dark, your second image will be will be taken at normal exposure and your third image will be over exposed, meaning that all the detail will be very bright. Remember that you can recap lesson 1 of Module 4 to get the grips of these photographic terms if you forgot what it meant.

Now, your smartphone or digital camera might have the ability to create HDR or panoramas but you have the capability to do this in Photoshop as well. Photoshop allows you to tweak and adjust your settings the way you prefer and thus gives you a lot more creative freedom.

Automate demo

Panoramic image:

1. In Photoshop, Choose File > Automate > Photomerge. You can also invoke this command from within Lightroom for a selected group of images (right-click > Edit In > Merge to Panorama in Photoshop).

2. Click the Use pop-up menu and choose Files (to select individual images) or Folders (to choose an entire folder).

3. Click the Browse button and navigate to the files or folder you want to use.

HDR image

1. Import the images into Photoshop. Go to the Automate menu (File; Automate; HDR Pro) and choose Merge to HDR Pro.

2. Change to 32-bit. Photoshop will give you all your images along with one of two dialogs. The first, simpler dialog means you're in 32-bit, while the second, busier one indicates you're using 16-bit.

3. Remove Ghosts. Layering multiple exposures, especially in situations where some of the content in the image is moving, will result in ghosting between the images. Simply click on Remove Ghosts, and Photoshop will correct the image.

4. Tone the image. Use Camera RAW for toning. If you use Photoshop CC, simply click "Tone in ACR". If you use Photoshop CS6 or Lightroom 5, save a 32-bit .tif file, then go into Photoshop's file handling preferences and tell Camera RAW to open those .tif files. Now, you can use your familiar controls to adjust the exposure, open shadows, introduce clarity, add warmth, and make any otheradjustments you desire.

Make an animated GIF

Social media networks, including Pinterest, Twitter, and Facebook, have sparked an animated GIF renaissance. More than a few online retailers are regularly posting GIF animations to attract and engage potential customers.

Animated GIF

So, why not learn to create your own? Gif stands for graphics interchange format. It basically includes a series of frames or images that are played in sequence to create the illusion of a short video clip but in image format.

In the early years of the web, animated GIFS were quite popular to add motion to websites and included advertisements or banners. Today, it is used mostly as memes or advertisements since most platforms support animated GIFs.

Build an Animated GIF with Pictures Demo

Step 1: Arrange the Images as Layers

Step 2: Open the Photoshop Timeline

Step 3: Lay Out the Timeline

Step 4: Add Tweens

Step 5: Set Frame Duration and Looping

Conclusion

Recapping on what we've learned today; we looked at creating Actions and Brushes Photoshop. From there, we moved onto using Photoshops automate Function. Then we discussed how to make your very own animated GIF from existing images. This lesson helped us hone in on the Power Tools that Photoshop has to offer, this will speed up our work flow and add a super power to our Photoshop skills.

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